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Revision Date:
09/01/2021

Background:
Verification is the use of third-party information or documentation to establish the accuracy of statements on the application.

Purpose:
This section details mandatory and optional verifications for CalFresh and the different ways to verify.

Policy:
The household has primary responsibility for providing required verification and to resolve any questionable information. Before requesting additional verifications from the household, the Human Services Specialist (HSS) is to attempt verification via electronic means such as Income Eligibility Verification System (IEVS), Payment Verification System (PVS), Medi-Cal Eligibility Data System (MEDS) and the Work Number (WN). If unable to verify or information is questionable, send a request for information to the household. Do not limit verification to any single type of document. Assist customers in obtaining required verifications as needed. Use a collateral contact or home visit if necessary.

Households or the Authorized Representative may provide verification in person, through the mail, online, fax, or email. Any reasonable verification provided by the household will be accepted and used to verify the statements given on the application. Issue receipts to CalFresh applicants and recipients when they submit verifications in-person at the office. When documents are submitted other than in person, a receipt is not required.

1. Questionable Information:

For information to be considered questionable, the information on the application must be inconsistent with statements made by the applicant, with other information on the application or previous applications, or with information received by the County.

When determining if information is questionable, base the decision on the household's individual circumstances. For example, a report of expenses exceeding the household's income prior to deductions may be grounds to request verification or additional verification. A household reporting no income while still managing their financial affairs could justify the need for an additional verification request.

These circumstances, however, will not be grounds for an immediate denial or discontinuance. Instead, explore with the household how they are managing their finances, whether the household receives excluded income or has resources, and how long the household has managed under these circumstances. When verification is required to resolve questionable information, the HSS must document in case comments:

- Why the information is considered questionable, or at a minimum indicate where in the case the inconsistency exists
- What documentation was used to resolve the questionable information (if it is resolved) and if applicable, the reason why an alternate source of verification such as a collateral contact or home visit was needed

2. Mandatory Verifications:
Verification must be obtained in these categories if it is applicable to the household.

- Gross Non-Exempt Income: Determine the amount to be used for certification purposes based on the best available information. Households must provide information about income received during the 30 days prior to submission of their application or recertification. For recertifications, staff must verify a change in income if one of the following circumstances occur: the source has changed, the amount has changed by more than $50, or if the information is incomplete, inaccurate, inconsistent, or outdated (See 63-220 and 63-304).
- Non-Citizen Eligibility: Verify the immigration status of those non-citizens who are **applying** for CalFresh benefits. See Processing Guide 117-02 for additional information regarding non-citizen eligibility.
- Identity: See 63-152 for information regarding identity. See the Verification Requirements Chart for additional information.
- Social Security Numbers (SSN): Households must provide the SSN of each member or provide verification of application for an SSN prior to certification. If individuals have more than one SSN, all numbers are required. See 63-161 for additional SSN information.
- Residency: Verification of residency in the County of San Diego will be accomplished to the extent possible using the verification of other information such as, identity or as a last resort the customer's statement on the Statement of Facts (SOF). See 63-152 for additional residency information.

3. Mandatory Verifications That Do Not Impact Eligibility:
Verifications obtained in these categories do not impact eligibility, however, they do impact benefit allotment amount. Failure to provide the verification is not a basis for denying or discontinuing a case if the person is otherwise eligible. If verification is not provided, the expense, exemption, or exclusion is not allowed.

- Medical Expenses: Prior to allowing the Excess Medical Deduction or Standard Medical Deduction (SMD), verify the amount of medical expenses that are deductible as listed in 63-232.
- Disability: Receipt of any of the benefits listed below qualifies as verification of disability:.
  - Social Security Disability Benefits
  - Disability Retirement Benefits
  - Disability Related Medi-Cal Assistance - Verify through county records that the individual receives disability based Medi-Cal as determined by the State Program Disability Determination Service Division (DDSD).
  - Veteran Related Disabilities
  - Railroad Retirement
- Student Exemption: A customer's statement is sufficient evidence that a student meets one of the exemptions unless the information provided is questionable or when a student's claim of physical or mental unfitness is not evident.

- Legally Obligated Child Support and Actual Payments: Verify child support or obtain payment information from the Local Child Support Agency (LCSA) automated data files if the data is available. Once the verification is received, the circumstances need not be verified again unless there is a change in the legal obligation or an increase in the amount of the payment. See 63-224 for additional child support payments exclusion information.

4. Optional Verifications:

Below is a list of items that fall under optional verifications. Optional verifications are non-mandated and must only be requested if relevant information is questionable. Request optional verifications for the purposes of maximizing benefits, however they must be marked as "optional" on the request. Failure to provide verification of optional verifications must not result in a denial or discontinuance or cause a delay in the determination of eligibility.

- Dependent Care Costs: Dependent care costs can be verified through an affidavit on the application, the Dependent Care Cost Affidavit or other affidavit. The household must specify under penalty of perjury on the affidavit:
  - The name of the provider
  - The total amount billed
  - The amount of out-of-pocket expenses
  - The amount of any subsidies

  Once verified, the expense will not be verified again unless the provider has changed, the amount has changed (which could affect the amount of the deduction) or the expense is questionable. See 63-233 for additional information regarding dependent care costs.

- Liquid Resources and Loans: A legally binding agreement is **not** required. A simple statement signed by both parties indicating the payment is a loan that must be repaid, is sufficient for verification.

  If the household receives payments on a recurring or regular basis from the same source, but claims the payments are loans, request a statement or affidavit from the provider of the loan stating repayments are being made, or that the payments will be made in accordance with an established repayment schedule. See 63-200 for additional information regarding resources.

  Note: The resources of Categorically Eligible (CE) and Modified Categorical Eligible (MCE) households will not be evaluated. See 63-201 and 63-120 for additional information regarding CE and MCE.

- Household Size/ Composition: If separate household status is questionable, individuals who claim to be a separate household from those with whom they reside will be responsible for proving that they are a separate household. See 63-101 for additional information.

- Standard Utility Allowance (SUA):
  Accept the customer's written or verbal statement as verification. See 63-236 for additional information regarding the SUA and the Standard Utility Assistance Subsidy (SUAS).

- Rent/Mortgage Expense:

A narrative entry of the amount claimed is required. Accept and document any verification of shelter costs voluntarily provided by the household. See 63-235 for additional information regarding shelter deductions.

Reminder: Shelter expense changes reported mid-period are considered verified upon receipt (VUR). See 63-284 for additional information on VUR.

- Citizenship – Acceptable forms of verification include:
  - Birth certificates, religious records
  - Certificates of citizenship N-560 or its replacement N-561 (for Acquired/Derivative Citizenship)
  - An "Application for Certification of Naturalization" form N-600 for a child or form N-643 for an adopted child provided by United States Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS)
  - A United States (U.S.) passport

  If the above forms of verification cannot be obtained, accept a signed statement from someone who is a U.S. citizen declaring, under penalty of perjury, that the person in question is a U.S. citizen. The signed statement will contain a warning of the penalties for helping someone commit an intentional program violation. See 63-153 for information regarding citizenship.

  The member whose citizenship is in question will be ineligible to participate until proof of U.S. citizenship is obtained and will have his/her income and resources treated as an ineligible noncitizen. (See 63.244)

- Voluntary Quit and Reduction of Work Effort – Acceptable sources of verification include, but are not limited to:
  - The previous employer
  - Employee associations
  - Union representatives
  - Grievance committees or organizations

  The household will not be denied CalFresh, if they are unable to obtain the requested verification from these or other sources because the reason for the quit was from circumstances that for good reason cannot be verified, such as:
  - A resignation from employment due to discrimination practices
  - Unreasonable demands by an employer
  - The employer cannot be located

References:
7 CFR 273.2
MPP 300.5
All County Letters (ACL) 13-102, 14-54, 14-66, 14-100, 17-98, 19-86, 20-48, 20-135 and 21-24
All County Information Notices (ACIN) I-10-04, I-45-11 and I-45-11E
Processing Guides 117-01 & 117-02

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by 09/30/2024.

Approval for Release:

9-21-21

RICK WANNE, Director
Self-Sufficiency Services